

DESCRIPTIVE PHRASE BANK

Feelings & Scenarios — Cambridge O Level English Language (1123)

A bank of original, non-clichéd phrases for Section B compositions (descriptive and narrative) and for adding emotional and sensory depth to Directed Writing. Organised into Part 1: Feelings, and Part 2: Scenarios & Settings.

How to use this bank

Never lift a phrase word-for-word into an exam answer under pressure — that produces stiff, unnatural writing. Instead, read a phrase, notice the technique behind it (a precise verb, an unusual sensory detail, an indirect way of showing emotion), and use that technique to write your own version in the moment. The goal is to train the instinct to "show, not tell."

PART 1 — FEELINGS

Each entry shows the feeling conveyed indirectly — through action, physical sensation, or observation — rather than naming the emotion outright. This is the technique examiners reward in both descriptive and narrative writing.

Joy / Elation

- a laugh escaped before she could stop it
- he felt weightless, as though the ground had loosened its grip
- colour seemed to return to everything at once
- a grin tugged at the corners of her mouth despite herself
- the world narrowed to this one bright, ridiculous moment
- he wanted to tell every stranger he passed

Sadness / Grief

- the silence in the house had a weight to it now
- she folded the letter smaller and smaller, as if that might shrink the news
- his voice had the flat, careful sound of someone trying not to break
- the empty chair at the table said more than anyone did
- grief arrived in waves, receding just long enough to trick her into calm
- he kept reaching for his phone to tell her, forgetting, remembering

Fear / Dread

- her breath came shallow, as though the air itself had thinned
- every creak of the house sounded deliberate
- his hands found the doorframe before his mind caught up
- the silence on the other end of the line stretched too long
- cold crept up his spine before his brain named the danger
- she counted her own heartbeat to keep from screaming

Anxiety / Nervousness

- she rehearsed the sentence until it lost all meaning
- his leg bounced under the desk, a metronome for his nerves
- the clock's hands seemed to move faster than they should
- she checked the message three times, as though the words might change
- a knot tightened somewhere beneath his ribs
- he smiled too quickly, a beat too late to be convincing

Anger / Frustration

- the words came out sharper than she intended, and she let them
- he set the cup down harder than necessary
- her jaw ached from holding back what she really wanted to say
- the apology, when it came, felt three sentences too short
- he could feel the heat climbing from his collar to his ears
- she counted to ten and made it to four

Love / Affection

- she noticed she'd started saving the good stories to tell him first
- there was a particular quiet between them that needed no filling
- he recognised her laugh from two rooms away
- some habits had become theirs without either of them deciding it
- the smallest gestures carried the most weight — a saved seat, a remembered order
- she found herself smiling at nothing, just from thinking of him

Loneliness / Isolation

- the flat held the particular quiet of a place built for two people
- she began narrating her day to no one, just to hear a voice
- his phone stayed dark on the table, deliberately placed within reach
- even the crowd outside seemed to belong to someone else's life
- she'd learned the sound of every floorboard, out of sheer repetition
- the second cup of tea went cold, made from habit, not need

Nostalgia / Longing

- the smell of chalk dust dragged him back twenty years in an instant
- some part of her still expected the old house to be there
- the song came on and, for three minutes, she was fifteen again
- he kept the ticket stub long after the reason for keeping it had faded
- the street had changed, but her feet still knew the old shortcuts
- certain afternoons still smelled like that particular summer

Shame / Guilt

- she rehearsed the apology and still couldn't make it sound like enough
- he avoided his own reflection for the rest of the evening
- the words sat heavy in her chest, unsaid and unsayable
- he found reasons to leave the room whenever the subject came close
- she kept replaying the moment, editing it into something forgivable
- the silence that followed felt like a verdict

Hope / Determination

- she allowed herself, just once, to imagine it working out
- he tightened his laces like the decision had already been made
- the setback felt smaller once she'd written down the next step
- there was still time, she told herself, and almost believed it
- he kept the rejection letter as proof of how far he'd come since
- one more attempt, she decided, and this time she meant it

Confusion / Disorientation

- the explanation only produced more questions than it answered
- he replayed the conversation, trying to locate the exact moment it went wrong
- nothing in the room had moved, yet nothing felt familiar either
- she opened her mouth to respond and found she had no response ready

- the instructions made sense until the third line, and then made none
- he nodded along, several sentences behind everyone else

Relief

- the breath she'd been holding left her all at once
- his shoulders dropped an inch he hadn't realised they'd been carrying
- the news landed like something finally set down after miles of walking
- she laughed, too loudly, at nothing in particular
- the tension in the room dissolved before anyone said a word
- he read the message twice, just to be sure it was real

PART 2 — SCENARIOS & SETTINGS

Sensory and atmospheric phrases for common descriptive prompts. Mix sight, sound, smell, and touch rather than relying on visual description alone — this is a frequent examiner recommendation for reaching the top bands.

Storm / Bad Weather

- the sky had the colour of an old bruise
- rain came sideways, finding gaps no umbrella could cover
- thunder rolled in from somewhere behind the hills, unhurried and certain
- the wind stripped the last leaves from the trees in one motion
- gutters overflowed into the street with a steady, insistent rush
- lightning briefly turned the whole street the colour of daylight

Calm Nature / Countryside

- the field stretched out in long, unbroken lines of gold
- the only sound was the occasional shift of grass in the breeze
- sunlight fell in patches through the canopy, moving slightly with the leaves
- the river moved without hurry, catching the light in fragments
- the air carried the faint, sweet smell of cut grass
- birdsong threaded through the silence without disturbing it

City Street / Urban

- the pavement was a current of shoulders and umbrellas
- neon signs bled colour onto the wet tarmac
- car horns layered over one another into a single, constant note
- the smell of street food cut through the exhaust fumes
- billboards towered over the crowd, indifferent to it
- the city hummed even at this hour, never fully asleep

Night / Darkness

- the streetlights pooled into small islands of orange along the road
- the house settled into its usual creaks, one by one
- shadows stretched longer than the objects that cast them
- the moon offered just enough light to make the shapes uncertain
- the silence had texture at this hour, thick and complete
- somewhere a dog barked once, then thought better of it

Dawn / Early Morning

- the sky lightened by degrees, reluctant to commit to morning
- mist sat low over the fields, in no rush to lift
- the first birdsong arrived before the light did
- frost traced the edges of the windows in fine, careful lines
- the street was still and unclaimed, briefly, before the day began
- steam rose from the mug in slow, thinning curls

Crowd / Market

- voices overlapped into a single wall of sound
- the air carried spice, sweat, and frying oil in equal measure
- stallholders called out prices that dropped the longer no one bought
- elbows and baskets found their way past each other by instinct
- colour spilled from every stall — fabric, fruit, painted signs
- somewhere a vendor's radio fought to be heard over the noise

Danger / Conflict

- the street had emptied faster than it should have
- somewhere close, glass gave way with a sharp, final sound
- every shadow seemed to hold its breath
- the silence that followed the noise was worse than the noise itself
- instinct moved his feet before his mind agreed to it
- the smoke reached the street before the sirens did

Hospital / Illness

- the corridor smelled of antiseptic and something harder to name
- the machine's steady beep was the only thing marking time
- voices in the hallway dropped to a practised, careful softness
- the waiting room chairs had the particular stiffness of long use
- she watched the second hand more closely than she meant to
- the news, when it came, arrived in a doctor's measured, rehearsed tone

Celebration / Festival

- the street had transformed overnight into colour and noise
- music spilled from every open doorway, none of it in time with the rest
- the smell of roasting food drifted over the whole square
- children wove between the adults' legs, too excited to stay still
- lanterns swung gently overhead, catching the last of the light
- laughter rose above the music in short, sudden bursts

Silence / Emptiness

- the room held its stillness like something deliberate
- dust hung undisturbed in the single shaft of light
- the clock's ticking was the loudest thing in the house
- her footsteps sounded too loud on the bare floor
- the house had the particular quiet of somewhere recently left
- nothing moved except the curtain, faintly, in a draught from nowhere

Journey / Travel

- the platform blurred into motion the moment the train pulled away
- the road unspooled ahead, marked only by the occasional passing light
- the airport hummed with the low static of a hundred separate goodbyes
- landscape gave way to landscape, indifferent to the hours it took

- the suitcase felt heavier with every hour of walking
- somewhere past the window, the horizon kept its distance

School / Exam Hall

- the clock above the board seemed to move slower than the rest
- pencils scratched in an uneven, nervous rhythm across the room
- the instructions were read out in the same flat tone as always
- someone's chair scraped, and half the room flinched
- the paper's questions swam briefly before settling into sense
- the final bell arrived both too soon and not soon enough

Coastal / Sea

- the tide dragged the shingle back with a long, hissing sigh
- salt hung in the air long before the sea came into view
- gulls wheeled overhead, calling to no one in particular
- the horizon blurred where the grey sea met the greyer sky
- waves arrived in an unhurried, practised rhythm
- the wind carried the cold straight through every layer

Forest / Wilderness

- the canopy swallowed most of the daylight before it reached the ground
- twigs gave way underfoot with small, sharp snaps
- the deeper they walked, the more the trees seemed to close behind them
- somewhere unseen, something moved through the undergrowth
- the air smelled of damp bark and old leaves
- shafts of light fell in narrow columns between the trunks

Passage of Time

- the paint had faded to a colour with no name
- the calendar on the wall was three months out of date
- dust had settled into the grooves of things no longer touched
- the garden had reclaimed what the fence used to hold back
- the photograph had yellowed at the edges, softening every face in it
- some habits outlived the reasons anyone had started them

Extension task: after each past paper Section B attempt, add 2–3 original phrases of your own to this bank, written in your own voice rather than copied from a model answer.